

learn," says Dayanand.

It was only after Sujeet graduated from school that he decided to focus solely on becoming a wrestler. "I was in the non-medical stream and initially thought about preparing for the JEE (Joint Entrance Exam). I even gave a few mock tests. But after my Class 12 exams, my father said I had to choose which direction I wanted to go. I finally decided I wanted to be a wrestler. I loved the sport. When I was growing up, I'd watch videos of Sushil (Kumar) and Bajrang (Punia). I used to really enjoy those videos. I was good in studies, of course, but I felt I could do more for myself and the country as a wrestler," says Sujeet. He moved to Sonipat to train with coach Kuldeep Singh, who recalls the youngster standing out particularly because of his intelligence. "He didn't have any big results at the age-group levels for two reasons. One, of course, was because he was managing his studies alongside his sport. The second was that, unlike a lot of junior athletes, he never changed his age to get an unfair advantage. But his best quality was just how quickly he picked up things. He started training at our academy in 2021, and within four years, he's now one of the best wrestlers in India," says Kuldeep.

Atypical Indian wrestler

The unorthodox route Sujeet has taken in his career has influenced the kind of wrestler he is. "Most of the top Indian wrestlers have a game that is based on tiring out opponents. That's because the training that most of them have is designed to build up stamina. When I watch someone like Bajrang *pehelwan*, it's really exciting because he wrestles for all six minutes, and when he is competing, you always know that even if he is trailing in the score, he will break the opponent physically and then come back in the last few seconds of the match," says Sujeet. "It's fun to watch, but I can't wrestle that way. When I started wrestling, I was always drilled on technique. Even now I'm more of a technical wrestler," he says.

That's what coach Kuldeep identifies as Sujeet's strength too. "He's not going to tire out an



Method wrestler: "I was always drilled on technique, that's the kind of wrestler I've become," says Sujeet.

opponent. But he's very sharp and explosive. He doesn't like to give away easy points, and if he can, he will try to finish off matches as early as possible," says Kuldeep.

Ever since making his senior national debut in 2022 — where he won silver — Sujeet has made a concerted push to claim the top spot in one of India's marquee weight categories. While he emerged as the national representative in 2024 after winning the selection trials, Sujeet admits that he still has some way to go before cementing his place in the Indian squad.

His loss at the Olympic Qualification Tournament only further motivated him. "That tournament gave me the confidence that I could compete at a very high level, but it also helped me to understand just where I have to improve. I used to do very little strength training before last year. I was mostly just doing mat practice. I've added a lot more strength training to my routine now. If I give myself about 70 out of 100 when it comes to my technique, I think I will give myself about 50 out of 100 when it comes to my strength.

"I went to train in Japan and Russia, and both of those gave me the opportunity to polish my

technique," he says.

Double World goal

While he had hoped to push his case further at the Asian Championships at the start of the year, an unlucky injury to his right ankle in his second bout forced him to forfeit the remainder of the tournament. The injury, diagnosed as a ligament tear, took nearly two months to heal.

The Budapest Ranking Series marked his comeback. It was just one tournament, but the nature of his dominance suggests the injury is firmly behind him. It's also a timely boost as Sujeet gears up for the rest of the season.

"My goal for this season is to medal at both the Senior and U-23 World Championships (in September and October of this year). I know I have the capability of doing both," he says.

There's a long-term goal too. Although he doesn't specify the details, the Los Angeles 2028 poster in his room in Sonipat hints at it. Having fallen short of making it to Paris 2024, he's determined not to miss out again. "By the next Olympics I want to be confident that I am as ready and well prepared as I can be," he says.